

Article **PDF Available****"Why Should I Read the Privacy Policy, I Just Need the Service": A Study on Attitudes and Perceptions Toward Privacy Policies**November 2021 · [IEEE Access](#) PP(99):1-1DOI:[10.1109/ACCESS.2021.3130086](#)License · [CC BY 4.0](#)**Authors:****Duha Ibdah****Nada Lachtar**
University of Michigan–Dearborn**Satya Meenakshi Raparathi**
University of Michigan–Dearborn**Anys Bacha**[Citations \(64\)](#)[References \(65\)](#)**Abstract**

Online service providers are aggressively evolving the digital systems around us into surveillance platforms. From voice assistants that listen to every conversation, to apps that share sensitive location information, privacy experts have raised concerns about how such data is being abused. This comes at a time when advertisement campaigns can target users through social media platforms according to political party affiliations, reproductive health, and even religious beliefs. Such behavior raises concerns about how service providers leverage privacy policies to legitimately appropriate private data. In this work, we examine the user attitudes and perceptions towards privacy policies. We analyze user perceptions based on data collected from 655 participants. We use this information to identify different motivators and blockers that can influence the user's willingness towards reading privacy policies. We also examine the impact of previous user experiences such as cyber attacks, as well as, online data sharing practices on reading such policies. Furthermore, we evaluate the ability of users to comprehend the content presented in privacy policies and the impact technical jargon has on the readability of such documents. Our study reveals that although less than 19% of our participants reported having some difficulty in understanding privacy policies, our study shows that more than half of the participants did not understand the content. Finally, we evaluate the implication of using different interfaces for conveying privacy policy content. We use this information to extract various pain points that could be used to assist researchers in improving the usability of privacy policies.

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This article has been accepted for publication in a future issue of this journal, but has not been fully edited. Content may change prior to final publication. Citation information: DOI 10.1109/ACCESS.2021.3130086, IEEE Access

Digital Object Identifier

"Why Should I Read the Privacy Policy, I Just Need the Service": A Study on Attitudes and Perceptions Towards

ABSTRACT

Online service providers are aggressively evolving the digital systems around us into surveillance platforms. From voice assistants that listen to every conversation, to apps that share sensitive location information, privacy experts have raised concerns about how such data is being abused. This comes at a time when advertisement campaigns can target users through social media platforms according to political party affiliations, reproductive health, and even religious beliefs. Such behavior raises concerns about how service providers leverage privacy policies to legitimately appropriate private data. In this work, we examine the user attitudes and perceptions towards privacy policies. We analyze user perceptions based on data collected from 655 participants. We use this information to identify different motivators and blockers that can influence the user's willingness towards reading privacy policies. We also examine the impact of previous user experiences such as cyber attacks, as well as, online data sharing practices on reading such policies. Furthermore, we evaluate the ability of users to comprehend the content presented in privacy policies and the impact technical jargon has on the readability of such documents. Our study reveals that although less than 19% of our participants reported having some difficulty in understanding privacy policies, our study shows that more than half of the participants did not understand the content. Finally, we evaluate the implication of using different interfaces for conveying privacy policy content. We use this information to extract various pain points that could be used to assist researchers in improving the usability of privacy policies.

I. INTRODUCTION

THE unprecedented growth of available data has transformed the way we approach everyday computing. The mobility of today's devices, fused with advances in cloud computing, continue to drive new synergies in the way online services are delivered to consumers, resulting in vast amounts of generated data [1]. This trend is exacerbated by the advent of the Internet of Things that is collecting staggering amounts of granular data on users that companies are increasingly harnessing for commercial purposes. Such commercial use, however, has been fraught with concern, prompting privacy advocates to sound the alarm on the risks associated with such practice. Unfortunately, despite a multitude of lawsuits and multi-million dollar settlements carried out against such companies [2]–[4], online services

show no signs of abating, becoming increasingly invasive in the way they collect and exploit personal data.

In today’s interconnected world, service providers are aggressively evolving digital systems around us into surveillance platforms. From voice assistants that listen to every conversation [5], to apps that share sensitive location information as their users roam around town [6]–[8], privacy experts have raised concerns about how such data is being abused. This comes at a time when advertisement campaigns can target users through social media platforms according to political party affiliations, reproductive health, and even religious beliefs [6], [9], [10]. Such behavior raises an important question, “What entitles service providers to handle personal data in this fashion?” One way this question is being addressed is through privacy policies.

Privacy policies represent a legal contract between users and service providers. However, who actually reads such policies before simply clicking “I Agree?” There is a general reluctance to actually reading such policies, even though they contain pertinent information related to people’s privacy and what parts of their personal data can be shared. Users often don’t understand the risks associated with accepting privacy policies, resulting in privacy loss. This is exacerbated by the evasive and vague language service providers purposely use while drafting their policies. In addition to privacy policies becoming more complex, they have become significantly longer. For instance, Google’s privacy policy evolved from 600 words back when it was a mere search engine to a whopping 4,000 word policy in order to reflect the practices the company engages in today [11].

Prior work examined privacy concerns of the general public with regards to their online activities. For example, a

for better privacy practices? In this question, we analyze the overall user awareness about data collection practices and the various concerns it raises for the sampled users. Furthermore, we evaluate the percentage of users who take actions after reading the privacy policy, including changing default permissions and using opt-outs. We then correlate these actions to the level of concerns users report. Finally, we assess the willingness of participants to use custom services instead, in order to improve their privacy.

Overall, our study shows that 77% of our participants reported having some experience in reading privacy policies with the vast majority of the participants (72.4%) indicating that concerns about the service provider is the main reason behind users attempting to read such policies. We also determined that only a small fraction of our participants (12%) felt that it was unnecessary to have privacy policies in the first place. Many users expressed a general distrust in the way their data was handled, citing a lack of transparency

found that 59% of their participants believed that it was possible to remain anonymous on the internet. They also found that participants were more proactive in taking steps to conceal their digital footprint from advertisers compared to the government knowing about their habits. In this work, we present a study on user attitudes and perceptions towards privacy policies. We analyze the reading behavior, frequency, and the user's susceptibility to change, in addition to categorizing what motivates the user's reading behavior. Furthermore, we divide the participants of this study into categories based on characteristics that lead to a change in behavior. We also evaluate their understanding of the content presented in privacy policies and their awareness of the actions they require. To this end, our study explores the following research questions:

Research Question 1: *Who reads the privacy policy and what is the user's general behavior towards such contracts?* In this question, we seek to understand the users' point of view on reading privacy policies, identify the characteristics of such users, understand how often they read such policies, and comprehend their general behavior towards keeping up with changes made to the terms of service.

Research Question 2: *What motivates users to read privacy policies and what prevents them from doing so?* In this question, we look into the reasons that motivate, prevent, and discourage users from reading privacy policies. We further analyze these reasons by grouping them into three categories, including: service, privacy policy, and user characteristics. In addition, we identify the main factors behind each category and how they impact consumers.

Research Question 3: *Do users understand the consequences of agreeing to the terms and services present in the privacy policy? We also explore the impact of these terms on users continuing to use the service once they understand the impact and if this would lead to any change in behavior*

over their data, irrespective of the claims made within the presented privacy policies. *"I believe that privacy is an illusion. You can blame my Political Science (BA) and Public Administration (MPA) background."* However, despite these views, in many cases, participants identified that loss of privacy was not enough of a deterrent for giving up the services they were accustomed to, *"Doesn't matter, I am not prepared to give up whatever services are involved so I just ignore the possible negatives like loss of privacy, etc."*

In addition to the aforementioned findings, our study shows that comprehension presented a major handicap in reading privacy policies. We found that although a mere 18.4% of our participants reported having some difficulty in understanding the privacy policy of popular websites, our study shows that 55% did not understand the actual content. For instance, while we found users to have an understanding of the impact of collecting information that directly links consumers to their identities, such as name, password, and IP address information, we found that users had little insight into the consequences of collecting geographical information such as location and signals and how this information could be abused. Finally, we find that although many users are not willing to give up the services they use in their entirety, 80% of them expressed willingness to consider non-customized services that don't rely on private data and

process. For instance, we found that participants shared the following views in response to some of the shady practices service providers engaged in: *"There's shady business going on behind the scenes. The Data industry is now the MOST VALUABLE industry in America."* Another participant said about service providers that, *"They aren't trustworthy, and you can't sue if they misuse your info anyway, because they all make us agree to 'binding arbitration'."* Others even suggested that service providers are under the impression that it is more economical for them to violate the terms and conditions of their contracts in return for continued collection and misuse of user data, *"They state they will delete data or that you can opt out of things but you really can't. It's cheaper for them to violate their own ToS and pay a fine than to give up the data they claim not to collect."* These statements strongly underscore how users feel about service providers and the dilemma of absconding by the privacy policies they draft.

Furthermore, our data shows that over 75% of our users felt negatively about the way privacy policies were designed and the content they embodied. To this end, users cited the aforementioned concerns as a serious source of apathy towards reading privacy policies. For instance, when asked about the ability to opt-out from data collection practices, our participants overwhelmingly felt that service providers tended to employ evasive dark patterns that are designed to inhibit users from opting out of their services. For example, multiple participants indicated that there was really no way to opt-out of a service, *"We live in an age where privacy is gone. We can pretend we have control with opt-outs but we really don't."* Similarly, another participant stated the following about opt-out options, *"Anywhere...or nowhere. They are just for show, to make people feel like they have control over their data."* The participants also felt that these services provided their users with little control

A. COMPREHENSION OF PRIVACY POLICIES

Prior work [13]–[20] has shown that online consumers often face considerable challenges in understanding the terms and conditions they agree to when signing up for a service. Different studies reported that the main inhibitor to the user's comprehension, after analyzing several policies in the wild, stems from the type of language employed in privacy policies. Studies found privacy policies to often be riddled with legal and technical jargon that makes them inaccessible to the average user. For instance, Luger et al. [20], conducted a study that focused on the readability of the terms of conditions of websites. More specifically, they examined the readability of the terms and conditions documents associated with webpages that belong to different energy companies within the U.K. They determined while using a readability formula known as SMOG [21], that a number of policies required comprehension levels that were well beyond the abilities of the average adult in the U.K. These findings raise concerns about the fact that a significant portion of the society tend to unknowingly consent to terms and conditions of websites they don't understand. To address these concerns, Luger et al. proposed the use of a browser plugin designed to assist with obfuscated language embedded in the terms and conditions documents once they are displayed to the user.

- We conduct a large scale survey consisting of 655 participants to evaluate user attitudes and perceptions towards contemporary privacy policies and provide researchers with insights into how past experiences can influence the behavior of users towards such policies.
- We evaluate various factors that serve as motivators and blockers for reading privacy policies and cluster the reasons into different categories based on these factors.
- We present participants with various privacy policies from popular websites and capture their reactions towards the sensitive data they collect. We also assess the participants' comprehension levels of privacy policies and the impact technical jargon has on the readability of such policies.
- We characterize the implication of using different interfaces for conveying privacy policy content and out-opt information. We use this information to extract various pain points that could be used to assist researchers in improving the usability of privacy policies.

II. RELATED WORK

A large body of work has explored different concerns related to privacy and data sharing practices when using online services. In this section, we discuss prior work that is closely related to our study, such as challenges associated with the readability of privacy policies and user perceptions on sharing data.

metric that is known as the Flesch Reading Ease Score (FRES) [23]. The authors of this study determined that over half of the privacy policies they selected in their study were inaccessible to more than 56% of the internet population due to the complexity of such policies. Similar findings were reported in another study that focused on policies related to the financial sector [17]. Other work by Graber et. al [18] focused on privacy policies related to health websites. They concluded that policies of the aforementioned websites required an average of two years of college in order for them to be understood, suggesting that the privacy policies used by health organizations are considered difficult to comprehend by most users. Other work by Proctor et al. [24] conducted a similar study on the readability of a diverse set of existing privacy policies and determined that a mean grade level of at least 13 years was required to understand the average online policy. Work by Pollach et al. [19] determined that many companies use modal verbs in order to make their policies vague. The study also suggests that privacy policies are written with litigation in mind instead of fair handling of user data. Other work [25] focused on analyzing various privacy policies related to social network websites. The authors also concluded that service providers often use difficult legal jargon that effectively renders the presented policies inaccessible to the average user. They also suggest that the readability of such policies is aggravated by the lack of consistency in terms that are employed across different websites. While

their study entailed reviewing privacy policies of different social networking websites and the type of data they collect, they did not survey any users on their perspective. Although many of these studies made an attempt to gain insight into how well privacy policies were understood by consumers, such studies did not consider the perspective of real users, but instead relied on various formulae such as SMOG as a way of assessing readability. Since readability is a much broader issue, our study relies on real participants reading various privacy policies and reporting on their perspectives.

B. USER PERCEPTIONS ON DATA SHARING

Multiple bodies of work [25]–[33] examined user perceptions on data sharing practices. For example, Fiesler et al. [27] examined public reactions in the wild in response to data sharing controversies and how news outlets shaped the attitude of users on privacy violations. Other work by Felt et al. [28] examined the behavior of mobile consumers and how permission requests influence users in forgoing the installation of such apps. On the other hand, work by Shklovski [29] investigated the attitudes of users towards apps accessing personal data, such as photos on their smartphones and how this affected their decision toward installing mobile apps. The study concluded that in general, users aren't necessarily careless about privacy, but rather they feel a sense of helplessness and would rather just benefit from using the service irrespective of what data is collected.

Work by Carrascal et al. [33] concluded that privacy concerns would be quiesced if service providers were open and direct about their data collection and usage instead of using evasive language. They determined that being more direct with users about how their data would be monetized, as suggested by Xu et al. [34] would reduce the perception

given service. A study by Habib et al. [36] showed that more than 90% of the tested websites offered opt-out options from email communication and targeted advertisement. Furthermore, 75% of the examined websites offered data deletion options. Unfortunately, the study also found that 80% of these websites omitted important details about how to opt-out of their services. A common theme amongst many privacy policies is ambiguity. The same study in [36] found that policies employed different formats and wordings for expressing similar information as a way of confusing consumers. For instance, Fabian et al. [37] conducted a large scale study of examining the readability of 50,000 website privacy policies. The authors found the average privacy policy length to have 1,700 words and required some college education to comprehend the studied policies. A general remedy to this problem lies in using privacy policy agreements to enforce consumer protection and control service provider misuse. For instance, the EU's General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) set some standards for privacy policies in Europe and enforced privacy regulations and transparency in order to protect consumer data. Linden et al. [38] found that GDPR generally motivated enhancement in the privacy policy's appearance and presentation of EU based websites. However, a downside to this approach is that it caused a considerable increase in length without structural improvement.

C. PRIVACY POLICY INTERFACES

Many researchers explored the enhancement of privacy policy interfaces in order to enhance comprehension and clearly communicate to consumers the available privacy controls [24], [26], [35], [39]–[41]. Tabassum et al. [26] explored the use of comic-based interfaces and their impact

trust. They found that a strong correlation exists between privacy policy, comprehension, and how users entrusted their information to be shared with online service providers. They concluded that the better the user understood the presented policies, the stronger the trust they had in the website handling their data. Finally, work by Leon et al. [32], focused on "online behavioral advertising" on websites. More specifically, they explored the willingness of users sharing data as a function of the data retention period and the ability of users to control the collected data and be able to delete it after expiration of the retention period. Unfortunately, they found that most services take an all-or-nothing approach on data collection which made users reluctant about sharing their information. Our study builds on many of these findings with more focus on how negative experiences, such as malware infections and identity theft impact users in sharing their personal information, as well as, how this affects their pro-activeness in considering other services.

Privacy policies are used to inform the user about how their data will be collected and consumed after using a

The authors determined that comic-based policies held user attention longer compared to text-based alternatives, and the consumers' comprehension level of the content improved. In addition, several other interfaces have been investigated for presenting privacy policies. For example, Lipford et al. [42] conducted a study that compared the tradeoffs between using the Audience View and Expandable Grids policy representations and how such interfaces translated to users changing their social network settings after going through the policies. In addition, this study suggested that combining these two interfaces presented users with better readability prompting many users to change the privacy and security settings of their accounts. Other work by Schaub et al. [43] explored the impact of a multi-dimensional design space including timing, channel, modularity and control, and the effects they have on easing the design of privacy notices and their integration into a system with minimal disruption to the system's interaction flow. Our study builds up on these interfaces, including other designs. We collect their feedback and discuss recommendations on how to improve privacy policy interfaces across mobile devices and standard

webpages tailored for the typical computer system.

D. THE PARADOX: PERCEPTION VS. BEHAVIOR

A variety of research work explored the privacy concerns of online users and the possibility of misusing it. An early study [44] discussed the concept of the "Privacy Paradox," which points to the reckless privacy behavior in spite of the existence of privacy awareness. This behavior may be a result of various theories such as social interactions, psychological impact, and economics [45]. Many studies explored the evaluation of online user data sharing behavior on social media in addition to their concerns towards privacy. For example, a study [46] on college students showed that many leverage their account profile settings to protect themselves against possible privacy violations. However, many online users, such as users with active Facebook accounts, tended to share more sensitive data without any awareness of how their information was viewable by unintended audiences and how existing tools could be leveraged to limit access to such data [47], [48]. Other studies discussed how users manage their privacy concerns by limiting access to their data [49], or by stopping the use of such platforms [50], [51]. For instance, [52], [53] examined the understanding of the risks associated with data sharing practices and found that participants do indeed understand the risks associated with making their data public. However, the study also concluded that users often felt a lack of control over their shared data due to the ambiguity of what was being collected and by whom.

Other work focused on consumers reading privacy policies in response to notices sent by service providers. A study by Milne et al. [54] investigated why online consumers read privacy notices across a variety of situations. The authors found that the reading of such notices is typically related to concern for privacy, positive perceptions about notice comprehension, and higher levels of trust in the notice. In addition, the authors determined that consumers generally felt that reading privacy notices represented the only element in an overall strategy consumers use to manage the risks of

A. PILOT STUDY

We created a preliminary survey to explore user perceptions of our research questions and to ensure quality survey questions. We recruited 36 local participants from our university to complete the initial survey prior to launching the full study. The age group of the participants ranged between 18 and 44. The gender breakdown of this group was 44.4% male and the remaining 55.6% were female. We analyzed the data obtained from this initial group of participants and used this information to refine our survey questions in preparation for the final study. None of the data collected during the pilot phase was incorporated in the analysis of the final study.

B. DATA COLLECTION

The survey was approved by our Institutional Review Board (IRB) before it was published on the Amazon Mechanical Turk platform for recruiting participants. All the participants resided in the United States and were 18 years old or older. Participants were also required to have a HIT approval rate of over 95% and more than 1000 completed assignments in order to participate in the survey. Mechanical Turk was selected for the ease of recruiting demographically diverse workers [57], [58], where the bias of these samples are well studied by [59]–[62]. Respondents had the option to withdraw at any point from the survey without providing any reason. The survey took approximately 25 minutes to complete. Each participant was awarded \$4 for completing the survey with payments carried out directly through the Amazon Mechanical Turk system. To ensure high quality responses, we included two attention check questions and only discussed the results of the participants who passed the attention checks.

We developed a systematic approach for answering our research questions. We gathered information about the education level of the different participants, security knowledge, amount of data shared using online platforms, and time spent online. We then examined the data for possible relationships across the aforementioned four factors to determine if any correlation existed between knowledge in security, online

participants clicked on the policy link during engagement with a fictitious search engine. Similarly, Obar et al. [56] conducted a study on people ignoring privacy policies and terms of agreement. The authors determined that 35% of their participants acknowledged not reading the privacy policies for any of the services during the sign up process.

III. METHODOLOGY

In this section, we outline our approach for creating the survey and collecting the data. Furthermore, we describe the analysis approach we use in this study.

privacy policies?” Below is a high level overview of the questions we used for collecting our data.

C. THE SURVEY

Our survey addresses five main areas: (1) demographics and information about general online practices (2) security and privacy concerns (3) behavior towards privacy policy (4) reaction towards provided policy specifications. (5) and reflection about the survey. Below is a high-level overview of the questions we used for collecting our data.

Time Spent and Information Shared Online: We asked participants questions about their online habits including the average time they spend online, and the type and quantity

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... • User Experience: Positive and negative experiences directly shape and influence an individuals' awareness, opinions, and expectations regarding privacy. It can be considered part of the Antecedents in the APCO model (previous experiences contribute to privacy concerns) [37,[40][41][42]49,[58][59] [60] [61]. • General Knowledge and Understanding of Privacy: User privacy awareness begins with knowledge of general privacy concepts. ...

... These findings are in line with those found in a study conducted in Croatia [49], where researchers found that previous negative experiences did not affect the level of interest and behaviors toward privacy protection. In contrast, another study observed that participants significantly changed their behaviors after experiencing privacy violations, and they began to read privacy policies more frequently [60]. These contrasting findings highlight the need for further research on the relationship between negative experiences, privacy awareness, and behavior. ...

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... This has been shown especially for the case of PPs including sensitive health or genetic information (Reidenberg et al., 2014;Yerby & Vaughn, 2022). Other studies have shown that consumers apart from the complex language rarely read the PP (Ibdah et al., 2021; Obar & Oeldorf-Hirsch, 2020;Steinfeld, 2016). This motivates research into automatic summarization methods that can make such documents more accessible and transparent. ...

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"We Are the Product": Public Reactions to Online Data Sharing and Privacy Controversies in the Media

April 2018

Casey Fiesler · Blake Hallinan

As online platforms increasingly collect large amounts of data about their users, there has been growing public concern about privacy around issues such as data sharing. Controversies around practices perceived as surprising or even unethical often highlight patterns of privacy attitudes when they spark conversation in the media. This paper examines public reaction "in the wild" to two data ... [\[Show full abstract\]](#)

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Defining Privacy: How Users Interpret Technical Terms in Privacy Policies

July 2021 · Proceedings on Privacy Enhancing Technologies

Jenny Tang · Hannah Shoemaker · Ada Lerner · Eleanor Birrell

Recent privacy regulations such as GDPR and CCPA have emphasized the need for transparent, understandable privacy policies. This work investigates the role technical terms play in policy transparency. We identify potentially misunderstood technical terms that appear in privacy policies through a survey of current privacy policies and a pilot user study. We then run a user study on Amazon ... [\[Show full abstract\]](#)

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Thesis

A Systematic Evaluation of System-level Threats and User Perceptions on Data Security and Privacy

July 2022

Duha Ibdah

An immense amount of data is produced every day thus creating a global digital economy that relies primarily on this data. This provokes misconduct in the form of threats to data security and privacy. For instance, adversaries are motivated to extract user data targeting personal devices on their way to compromising data confidentiality and evading detection. Thus compromising lower levels of the ... [\[Show full abstract\]](#)

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Chapter

Benutzbare Lösungen für den Datenschutz

January 2018

Dominik Herrmann · Simone Fischer-Hübner

Der Schutz der Privatsphäre spielt bei vielen Informationssystemen eine wichtige Rolle, ist jedoch oft nicht das primäre Ziel der Benutzer. Die implementierten Maßnahmen müssen daher gut benutzbar sein, um akzeptiert zu werden. Ein Hauptziel des Datenschutzes besteht darin, die Erfassung und Verarbeitung von Daten auf das für einen bestimmten Zweck erforderliche Minimum zu beschränken. Am ... [\[Show full abstract\]](#)

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